First News

25 Mar 2026

Employing Intelligent investing, a disciplined, long-term approach to wealth creation based on fundamental analysis, risk management, and emotional control.

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Global, Regional Markets

Wall Street closed in the red on Tuesday, as initial optimism from a potential diplomatic breakthrough in the U.S.-Iran war faded. Rally was sparked by hints of de-escalation, markets reversed course when Iranian officials denied that any direct negotiations had taken place.

The S&P 500 was down 0.37% and Nasdaq 100 sank 0.77% with oil futures climbing on concerns of conflict in the Middle East escalating.

Cracks are showing in the $1.8T private credit market.

- Heavyweights Ares & Apollo just slapped the brakes on investor withdrawals.
- Ares limited redemptions to just 5% after clients tried to pull out 11.6% of its $10.7B Strategic Income Fund.

Oil prices stayed below $100 as fighting continued. Oil's volatility threatens corporate margins and fuels broader inflationary concerns.

Saudi Arabia is taking steps that indicate it is moving closer to joining the ongoing conflict with Iran. This shift in policy comes after sustained Iranian attacks on Saudi and UAE energy infrastructure.

The Wall Street Journal reported that..U.S. allies in the Persian Gulf are getting tougher following persistent attacks that have disrupted their economies and risk giving Tehran long-term leverage over the Strait of Hormuz

- As of today March 24, 2026, there is no official ceasefire between the United States and Iran, but President Donald Trump has announced a temporary 5-day pause on specific military strikes.

The contradiction: Iranian officials denied any talks took place.

- Trump simultaneously issued a 48-hour ultimatum to reopen the Strait of Hormuz or face attacks on Iranian power plants. Iran threatened to close the Strait entirely. The situation remains fluid

US has held talks with Iran & suspended any further airstrikes for five days, sending oil prices tumbling.

- Gold pares losses, nearing $4,330, while silver trims earlier declines of amid mounting inflation concerns

DA MARKET SECURITIES

Asia-Pacific

	3/24/2026	3/25/2026	%Chg
Dow Jones	46,208	46,124	-0.18%
S&P 500	6,581	6,556	-0.38%
NASDAQ	21,946	21,761	-0.84%
PCOMP	5,899.00	5,936.00	0.63%
NKY	51,515.00	52,252.00	1.43%
SHCOMP	3813	3881	1.78%
HSI	24,382.00	25,063.00	2.79%
KOSPI	5405	5553	2.74%
SENSEX	72,696.00	74,068.00	1.89%
TWSE	32,722	32,612	-0.34%
ASX200	8365	8379	0.17%
BURSAKLCI	1720	1708	-0.70%
JCI	7106	7106	0.00%
STI	4841	4862	0.43%
SET	929	939	1.08%
VNINDEX	1591	1614	1.45%

DA MARKET SECURITIES

Commodities - Metals & Agriculture

	3/23/2026	3/24/2026	%Chg
WTI Crude	89.78	88.84	-1.05%
Brent Crude	100.92	104.49	3.54%
Gold (Comex)	4465	4578	2.53%
Silver (Comex)	69.58	72.98	4.89%
Platinum Spot	1893	1955	3.28%
Copper (Comex)	548	554	1.09%
Nickel	7.5373	7.6362	1.31%
Nickel Ore Phl 1.5%	80	80	0.00%
Nickel Ore Phl 1.8%	94.5	94.5	0.00%
Coal	140.5	139.75	-0.53%
Corn	461.25	462.5	0.27%
Wheat	592	590	-0.34%
Cocoa	3180	3235	1.73%
Sugar	15.52	15.88	2.32%

DA MARKET SECURITIES

Strategy

Philippines

PSEI closed positive at 5,936.20 +37.02 +0.63% Mines/Oil , Banks, Property, Holdings, Industrials tracked gains, Services declined. Value traded at P5.7 Billion, 129 advances, 63 declines & 59 unchanged Asian markets rebounded as investors reacted to signs of easing tensions

Philippines Sells PHP5.565 Billion 6.375% 2050 Bonds; Yield 7.4% Yield reflects recent market trends where long-term yields have climbed due to inflation concerns and global rate volatility

The iShares MSCI Philippines ETF (EPHE) is an exchange-traded fund designed to track the investment results of an index composed of Philippine equities, trading on the NYSE Arca. As of March 23, 2026, EPHE trades around $24.23, featuring a 2.17% dividend yield

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DA MARKET SECURITIES

Philippines

Employing Intelligent investing, a disciplined, long-term approach to wealth creation based on fundamental analysis, risk management, and emotional control,

5936 37.02pts., -1.98%

Range 5911-5948

Breadth 129 (+) 63 (-) 59 (unch)

Block Php921Mn **Volume** 633mn
Value Php5.69bn

Share buyback sm ict opm spmh meg

52wk H: fpi
52wk L: atn dito tech vlc

Overbought – none
Oversold – vlc lbc tech tugs fli at gtcap apo sm gsmi xg eli ali ubp

Active	Value
ICT	1,070
BDO	565
MBT	591
MYNLD	301
ALI	216
SM	208
BPI	146
URC	138
TEL	128

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DA MARKET SECURITIES

Foreign Trade

NFB(S)	$12.62mn
Total Month FS	$2.242mn
YTD NFB	$182.847mn
FB	4,028,354,795.69
FS	5,368,920,643.56
NFB(S)	1,340,565,847.87
TOTAL	9,397,275,439.25

Foreign Funds Bought
aub ew pnb secb dhi acen ap fph pcor shlph top emi keepr cosco jgs ltg ali areit creit filrt vreit glo tel cnvrg ceb mac sti sevn apx px

Foreign Funds Sold
bdo bpi cbc mbt mer mwc mynld scc sgp cnpf dnl fb gsmi jfc maxs monde rfm urc ac aev agi dmc gtcap sm smc mrc rcrc rlc smph ict bloom plus web pgold rrhi ssi wlcon fni ogp

Share Buy-Back Transactions
OPM SM MEG AGI URC SMPH

Smart Watch
secb glo web sevn rlc pgold filrt mreit apx scc glo fgen ceb pcor mac ogp sgp dmc rlc ltg acen

10yr Bond	3/24/20...	3/25/2...	%Chg
PHL	6.989	7.113	1.77%
US	4.358	4.353	-0.11%

Currency Pair	3/24/2...	3/25/2...	%Chg
USD-JPY	158.26	158.9	0.64%
USD-PHP	60.298	59.943	0.06%
USD-CNY	6.8798	6.949	0.24%
EUR-USD	1.1633	1.1569	-0.35%

NEWS, ANALYSIS , INVESTING INSIGHT

PXP 3.00

- **Philippine President Marcos Jr. has reiterated his openness to resuming talks with China regarding joint oil and gas exploration in the South China Sea.**

SMC 70.85 SCC 29.60 MER 603.50

- Three-way Semirara coal auction confirmed: SMPC (incumbent), MGEN/SMPC minority partnership, and SMGP (San Miguel, standalone). Application April 28; winners by May. Market pricing in base-case SMPC retention. May award is the binary catalyst.

TEL 1350.00

- VITRO signed with Bounty Fresh Group for data center and supply chain digitalization at VITRO Santa Rosa. Enterprise client base now covers banking, microfinance, and agri-food. Foreign funds sold TEL on the session current price levels offer better entry.

WEB 11.80

- PhilWeb launched OKADA PLAY with Okada Manila — second major resort client in three months (Hann Casino, January). Foreign funds bought WEB on March 23 — a standout signal during a risk-off session when PH funds were being broadly reduced.

TECHNICAL NOTE

Rounding Top SMPH & ALI

- A Rounding Top (also known as an Inverse Saucer) signifies a gradual shift in market sentiment from bullish to bearish. Appears at the end of a long-term uptrend, serves as a bearish reversal signal, suggesting that prices may begin a long-term decline.
- Institutional Distribution: On longer timeframes, it often represents large institutions slowly selling off their positions ("rotating out") without wanting to trigger a sudden price collapse.

ALI 17.46

- **Ayala Land Inc. (ALI) is currently exhibiting a strong bearish trend in the short to medium term.**
- 12M price target of 32.05 potential upside of 89%.
- P/E ratio of 6.2x, below the Philippine market average of 8x.

NEWS, ANALYSIS , INVESTING INSIGHT

ALI 17.46

- **ALI (Ayala Land) — Names Jaime Urquijo Head of Ayala Land Urban Estates**
- **A**yala Land has appointed Jaime Urquijo as head of Ayala Land Urban Estates — the unit responsible for the group's urban mixed-use and estate development projects. Urquijo concurrently serves as Ayala Corporation's chief risk officer, reflecting the Ayala group's practice of cross-deployment of senior executives across subsidiaries.
- **Analysis:** A management appointment story rather than a financial event. The notable subtext: Urquijo's dual role as ALI Urban Estates head and Ayala Corp. risk officer is a governance signal — it integrates risk management thinking directly into Ayala Land's most complex development vertical. Urban Estates encompasses flagship projects like BGC, Nuvali, and Arca South — the highest-value and most capital-intensive part of ALI's portfolio. In the current environment (ALI at 52-week lows, RSI 23.53, peso above 60), having risk management expertise directly embedded in leadership is meaningful. No direct earnings impact.
- **Stance:** Neutral event. Context: ALI remains in extreme oversold territory at ₱16.92 (RSI 23.53). BUY ON WEAKNESS remains the tactical stance for technically-oriented investors.

FLI 0.73

- **FLI / EW (Filinvest Land + EastWest Bank) — Launch Joint Home Financing Program**
- **F**ilinvest Land Inc. (FLI) and EastWest Bank have launched a co-branded home financing program offering buyers of Filinvest residential properties access to EastWest mortgage facilities streamlining the purchase-to-financing pipeline within the Gotianun group ecosystem.
- **Analysis:** This is a synergy play within the FDC conglomerate FLI (property) and EastWest Bank (banking, 40% of FDC's earnings) combining to offer a more seamless buyer experience. For FLI, it reduces buyer friction and potentially accelerates sales conversion on residential projects. For EastWest, it creates a captive mortgage origination channel within Filinvest's buyer base. Given EastWest's record ₱9.2B net income in FY2025 (driven by consumer lending), expanding the mortgage book via FLI's project pipeline is a logical next step. In the current rate environment (PHL 10yr approaching 7%), mortgage rates will be elevated but the co-branded offering may include preferential rates that sweeten the buyer proposition. Read-through: FDC's integrated model continues to deepen; cross-selling between banking and property is becoming a structural earnings driver.
- **Stance:** Positive read-through for FDC. Deepens banking-property synergies within the Gotianun group. ACCUMULATE FDC on the broader thesis; this deal reinforces the integrated model's edge.

NEWS, ANALYSIS , INVESTING INSIGHT

DMC 9.60

- **DMC (DMCI Holdings) Keeps ₱24.6B Capex Despite Higher Oil; Operating Costs Under Review**
- DMCI Holdings confirmed its capex program will proceed as planned even as the Middle East war raises fuel costs and supply chain concerns. CFO Herbert Consunji said: "The capex is set already so we just have to follow it. Of course, the operating costs will now be revisited." He flagged that the key concern is not just price but availability — "It's not a matter of price; it's a matter of availability... You may have money to buy it, but it's not available because the suppliers downgraded." He added that "everything will be reset" as conditions evolve. DMCI's 2026 capex of ₱24.6B is up 11% from ₱22.2B in 2025, with ₱15.5B (65%) allocated to property arm DMCI Project Developers.
- **Analysis:** The capex commitment holding is the right headline for investors — it means DMCI's residential construction pipeline, off-grid power expansion, and cement upgrades are not being scaled back. The more nuanced concern is operating cost and fuel availability. DMCI has significant fuel exposure across its construction (heavy equipment), power (diesel generators for off-grid), and mining (Semirara) businesses. The fuel availability point. not just price. is a material supply chain risk that markets may be underweighting. If Brent stays elevated and refinery throughput is disrupted, project timelines could slip even with committed capex. For SCC (Semirara), coal remains its core product; the Middle East context is actually supportive for coal demand and pricing (coal +5.13% last week as LNG disruption drives thermal coal substitution).
- S**tance: A**CCUMULATE DMC on weakness. Capex intact, fundamentals sound. Monitor fuel availability risk — it's the key operational variable, not just the price headline. SCC benefiting from coal demand spike; coal auction May award remains the binary catalyst.

NEWS, ANALYSIS , INVESTING INSIGHT

CEB 30.50
PAL 3.40

- **CEB / PAL — CAAP Airport Fees Cut Up to 50% from April 1; Government Aviation Relief Package**
- **T**he Department of Transportation ordered CAAP to reduce passenger service charges and landing/takeoff fees at all CAAP-operated airports starting April 1 for three months. International PSC drops from ₱900 to ₱700; domestic PSC falls from ₱350 to ₱150–₱200.Aeronautical fees including landing and takeoff will be reduced by up to 50%, translating to as much as ₱5,000 less per landing. Jet fuel costs have risen from $90.87/bbl on February 19 to $188.2/bbl on March 9. The CAB also shortened the fuel surcharge review period from one month to 15 days to allow faster airfare adjustments. Note: NAIA, Mactan-Cebu, Clark, Cagayan de Oro, and Bohol-Panglao (all PPP-managed) are excluded from this directive.
- **Analysis:** This is a targeted government intervention to arrest the aviation sector spiral and it matters meaningfully for CEB and PAL's cost structures on CAAP-managed routes. The ₱5,000/landing reduction on aeronautical fees adds up quickly across dozens of daily rotations to regional airports. The domestic PSC cut (₱350 → ₱150–200) removes ₱150–200 per ticket on regional flights, partially offsetting the CAB's fuel surcharge hike to Level 8. The critical limitation: NAIA, Mactan, and Clark the highest-volume airports are excluded because they're PPP-operated. So the relief is most relevant for Davao, Laoag, Zamboanga, and secondary domestic hubs. For CEB specifically, which has the widest domestic network of any Philippine carrier, this is a meaningful but partial offset to jet fuel economics. PAL separately suspended Manila–Dubai, Manila–Doha routes through April 30 on safety/operational grounds. The 15-day CAB review turnaround is the more important systemic relief — faster airfare adjustments mean airlines can respond to fuel price changes more dynamically.
- **Stance:** Incrementally positive for CEB and PAL. CAAP fee cuts provide partial operating cost relief on domestic regional routes. Does not resolve the NAIA economics or the fundamental jet fuel cost problem but it's a meaningful gesture from government. NEUTRAL to MONITOR for CEB; watch whether Brent de-escalation holds.

NEWS, ANALYSIS , INVESTING INSIGHT

PXP 3.00

- **PXP (PXP Energy) FEI Converts $10.2M Debt to Equity; FEPCO Increases Ownership to 91.65%**
- Forum Exploration Inc. (FEI), an indirect subsidiary of Pangilinan-led PXP Energy, will issue 561 million new common shares at ₱1 each to Forum Energy Philippines Corp. (FEPCO) to convert approximately $10.2M (~₱561M) in shareholder advances into equity. The conversion is intended "to strengthen FEI's balance sheet and improve its capital position by reducing outstanding obligations." Upon completion, FEPCO's ownership in FEI increases from 66.67% to approximately 91.65%. FEI holds a 100% operating interest in Service Contract No. 40 in Northern Cebu.
- **Analysis:** This is a balance sheet housekeeping exercise converting intercompany shareholder advances (essentially internal loans) into equity removes debt obligations and strengthens FEI's capital structure. It has no cash outflow and no external dilution impact since FEPCO is already within the PXP group. The strategic relevance: SC40 in Northern Cebu is an upstream oil exploration contract — and with Brent now at $100+, the optionality value of any Philippine upstream asset has increased materially. PXP's upstream portfolio is a leveraged play on oil prices. The cleaner FEI balance sheet positions the subsidiary for potential further activity on SC40. No immediate earnings impact, but strategically aligned with the current energy environment.
- **Stance:** MONITOR for PXP. Oil price environment is supportive of upstream asset re-rating. SC40 balance sheet cleanup is a quiet positive. The larger catalyst is any SC40 drilling or development announcement.

NEWS, ANALYSIS , INVESTING INSIGHT

TEL 1,350.00

- **TEL (PLDT/Smart) Smart + EdgePoint Deploy 20 Solar-Powered Towers; 181kWp Capacity, 198,000L Diesel Saved Annually**
- Smart Communications and EdgePoint Towers have deployed 20 solar-powered telecom towers across off-grid and underserved areas in the Philippines. PLDT COO Menardo Jimenez said: "Solarizing these towers significantly improves uptime and service continuity by giving our equipment a more dependable energy source." The installed solar capacity exceeds 181 kilowatt-peak, with battery storage over 20,000 ampere-hours. The initiative is expected to reduce diesel consumption by approximately 198,000 liters annually and avoid around 545 tons of carbon emissions each year. PLDT CSO Vergel de Dios added: "For us, sustainability is not separate from network performance it strengthens it."
- **Analysis:** The timing here is the story. PLDT deploying solar-powered towers at a moment when diesel costs have effectively doubled is not just environmental optics it's direct operational cost reduction and resilience insurance. At current oil prices, 198,000 liters of avoided diesel consumption translates to significant annual opex savings per site. The EdgePoint partnership (EdgePoint bought ~2,934 PLDT towers in the ₱77B tower sale) is also deepening a commercial relationship that benefits both parties: EdgePoint gets sustainable infrastructure economics; Smart gets improved uptime in off-grid areas. This is a small initial rollout (20 sites) but signals a scaling roadmap. For TEL, every tower solarized reduces the energy cost vulnerability that hits tower opex hardest.
- **Stance:** Incrementally positive for TEL. Operational cost reduction narrative + ESG alignment + resilience in the current fuel shock environment. This is a long-term network quality and opex story, not a near-term earnings mover.

- **In Memoriam: Napoleon "Polly" Nazareno, PLDT President & CEO 2000–2015, passed away at 77**
- Napoleon L. Nazareno, who served as president of PLDT and Smart Communications, has passed away at 77 following a spontaneous intracranial hemorrhage in Toronto. "Polly will be remembered for his kind heart, quiet strength, and remarkable vision. He devoted much of his life to helping shape the future of Philippine telecommunications," his family said.Nazareno led PLDT and Smart as president and CEO from 2004 to 2015, the period when Philippine telcos were competing for leadership in the mobile and unli-text era. He oversaw Smart's rise from third player to market leader, Piltel's landmark debt restructuring, and the integration of Digitel and Smart.
- A**nalysis:** No investment implication — this is an industry tribute. Nazareno retired from PLDT in 2015 and has not held an operational role since. His legacy is the operational and commercial foundation he built at Smart and PLDT during a transformative decade in Philippine telecoms — the DSL era, prepaid mobile dominance, and the Digitel acquisition. The industry's thoughts are with his family.